

asparagus, shitake mushrooms, bellpeppers and the vegetable tempura are a hit with diners at the specialty Japanese restaurant Tetsuma.

This is a phenomenon not restricted to Mumbai or Delhi alone. Given that many people down south are vegetarians, the demand for meatless variants of international delicacies is on the rise at a range of fine-dining restaurants. Sunny's, a Bangalore-based popular Mediterranean and continental restaurant, for instance, has seen a rise in demand for dishes it has created. The kitchen serves vegetarian variants of popular dishes like Chicken Mo-shu and Steak Diane. "Vegetarian regulars are very keen to try out new cuisines," says S. Mahesh, the restaurant's manager of 10 years.

From zucchini carpaccio, asparagus tempura, cauliflower bisques and vegetable dim sums, the frying pan is the new canvas of creativity. "Most traditionally, meat-based



A mock lamb preparation with soy sauce and spring onions, available at China Garden



Shitake and bell pepper Maki rolls available at The Trident, Nariman Point, Mumbai



Asparagus Sushi available at The Trident, Nariman Point, Mumbai



Kushiyaki platter containing hitake, potatoes, bean curd, asparagus and elephant garlic. Available at The Trident, Nariman Point, Mumbai

EDWARD WANG

From mock meat dim sums to vegetarian Chung Fun, his China Garden promises to turn around nearly 60 per cent of the menu into a vegetarian avatar

MANDAR DEODHAR

dishes can be created with vegetarian ingredients if the chef is creative and interested. South-East Asian dishes, for example, have common sauces, so the greens can easily replace the meats," explains James Biaka, executive chef at Tetsuma. At his restaurant, the toast of the table is the traditional Japanese Yakitori—grilled chicken speared on sticks—albeit in vegetarian form. While Biaka retains the original Yaki sauce, he replaces the chicken with shitake, traditional Japanese mushrooms.

At Mumbai's Olive Bar & Kitchen, Max Orlati, the restaurant's French chef, also acknowledges the trend. Recognising the changing trend in the selection of food, Olive has recently introduced an exclusive vegetarian menu. To assure patrons that they are serious about accommodating changed tastes, the management is, in fact, going the extra mile. Even in Delhi and Bangalore—other cities where Olive has branches, vegetarian menus are seeing a considerable expansion. Zucchini has replaced beef in the restaurant's signature dish Carpaccio, emerging in a brand new avatar. Similarly, Espetadas—Mediterranean skewers that traditionally contain parma ham, lamb, chicken and foie gras—find vegetarian alternates in cottage cheese, mushrooms and parmesan.

Not everyone wearing a chef's hat thinks the vegetarian spin is credible. For Orlati, such creations work, but he acknowledges that they can never be as perfect in taste as the authentic. "I believe that nothing beats an original recipe," says Orlati. At five-star hotels too, just as in independent restaurants, menus are adapting to the rise in demand for vegetarian dishes but not many see it as a revolution. "I don't think that bastardisation of a dish is the way forward," says Mahesh Kini, executive sous-chef at Hyatt Regency. He echoes Rahul Akerkar, proprietor and executive chef of Indigo Deli, who believes that passing off tempeh or soya cakes as meat is a "con job." While there clearly are differences over ingredients, vegetarians are certainly not complaining. ■

MAX ORLATI
Mumbai's Olive Bar & Kitchen's chef has created the restaurant's signature dish Carpaccio in a vegetarian format



BHASKAR PAUL